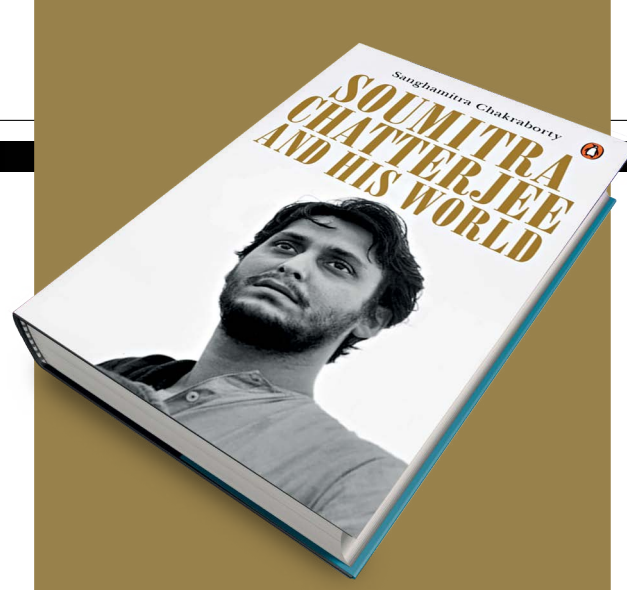


SOUMITRA CHATTERJEE AND HIS WORLD
by Sanghamitra Chakraborty
PENGUIN/ VINTAGE
₹**999; 512** pages

BOOKS

Cinema's Renaissance Man

SANGHAMITRA CHAKRABORTY'S DEEPLY RESEARCHED BIOGRAPHY EXPLORES THE LIFE AND LEGACY OF SOUMITRA CHATTERJEE

Since his death in 2020, there has been a spate of biographies attempting to chronicle the life and work of Soumitra Chatterjee. Not surprising, given he was an inseparable part of Bengali culture over a career spanning 60 years. His oeuvre included critically acclaimed films like *Apur Sansar* (1959) and *Ghare-Baire* (1984) to hits like *Teen Bhubaner Pare* (1969) and *Bela Seshe* (2015). Chatterjee's contributions, though, went far beyond films. A true polymath, Chatterjee also excelled as a playwright, poet, painter and essayist. Apart from editing the reputed literary magazine *Ekshan*, the actor also had a collection of his plays published in three volumes and had over a dozen poetry titles to his credit. It's not easy for a biographer to do justice to such a prolific subject, but author and journalist Sanghamitra Chakraborty manages just that, to give us the definitive account of his extraordinary life in her mammoth *Soumitra Chatterjee and His World*.

Chakraborty follows a chronological order while telling Chatterjee's story, starting with his childhood before tracing his journey into acting. As expected, his collaborations with Satyajit Ray form a substantial part of the book, pulling into focus the amount of work both artists put into each of their works. She reveals that during the making of *Apur Sansar*, the actor kept a journal in which he imagined what Apu would do between the scenes Ray had written—"a sort of a biography of Apu in the form of a diary". They made 14 films together, including bringing to screen the iconic detective Feluda in *Sonar Kella* (1971) and *Joi Baba Felunath* (1979).

While the actor's love and admiration for Ray was unquestionable, he did detest the assumption that he was the filmmaker's "puppet". Chakraborty also examines the actor's work with greats like Mrinal Sen and Tapan Sinha while acknowledging those films in his filmography that left his fans befuddled. She takes a nuanced look at the turmoil in his personal life and his growing concerns about the rise of religious intolerance. There are nuggets of information that stand out—his resemblance to a young Tagore played a part in his casting in *Devi* (1960) or the friendship between Chatterjee and fellow actor Uttam Kumar. The duo were often pitted as rivals but were friends from the moment they met on the sets of *Jhinder Bondi* (1961). And, in his later years, after many of his longtime friends and collaborators had passed on, Chatterjee found solace in art, especially doodling.

Chatterjee loved and admired Ray, but he detested the assumption that he was the filmmaker's 'puppet'

Across 10 sections and with a foreword by Sharmila Tagore (who debuted as Aparna to his Apu in *Apur Sansar*), Chakraborty doesn't just chronicle his life but often zooms out to place his life in the macro context of 20th- and 21st-century Bengal. She writes about how living through the 1943 Bengal famine, Partition and the Naxal movement shaped him. Along with his family, there were three people—his idol Tagore, the thespian and pioneer of modern Bengali theatre Sisir Kumar Bhaduri, and Satyajit Ray—who had a profound impact on Chatterjee. She weaves his writings—essays, diaries and poetry—along with his interviews and those with his colleagues to capture the essence of one of India's most remarkable artistes. This biography is not just for Bengalis or cinephiles who knew his works but also for those just starting to discover them. ■

–Karishma Upadhyay